

BIRTHDAY QUEST - GAME MASTER'S GUIDE + PLAYER PACK

The Starlight Birthday Heist

A joyful fantasy one-shot about a stolen wish, a lonely dragon, and the best party in Bellweather

3 HEROES	Level 3 QUICK-PLAY	2.5-3h RUN TIME	Age 13 AGE-TUNED
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THE PROMISE

During Bellweather's grand birthday festival, a young dragon steals the magical Starlight Candle. The heroes must chase it through the Candywood, uncover who is really spoiling the celebration, and decide whether the best ending is a victory...or an invitation.

What is included

- A complete scene-by-scene adventure with read-aloud text and a three-hour run of show.
- Two balanced encounters, both with peaceful alternatives and fail-forward clues.
- Three simplified level 3 heroes: a protector, a sneak, and a starry bard.
- Printable invitation, clue cards, player rules, and a Hero of Bellweather certificate.
- Experience, difficulty, and two-player adjustments so the game stays fun rather than fragile.

Assumptions

This packet is tuned for three 13-year-old player characters plus one Game Master, using familiar D&D 5e-style rules. The tone is adventurous and funny without talking down to the players. Use DC 12 for routine challenges and DC 13 when the pressure matters. If your group has only three people total, use the two-player adjustment on the scaling page.

QUICK PERSONALIZE

Handwrite the birthday hero's name on the invitation and certificate. Let the birthday child choose a hero first, then give every player one Make-a-Wish token so the spotlight stays shared.

Game Master's Quick Start

You can run the adventure directly from these pages. When a player tries something clever that the packet does not anticipate, choose a difficulty, ask for a d20 roll, and let a mixed result move the story forward.

Before everyone arrives

- Print or share the three hero pages, the Player Quick Rules page, and the invitation/clue page.
- Gather one d20 per player plus a few d4, d6, d8, and d10 dice. Tokens or coins can track Make-a-Wish uses.
- This age 13 version uses DC 12 for routine checks and DC 13 for risky or dramatic checks. If everyone is new, DC 12 throughout is fine.
- Privately ask whether anything should stay out of the story. Keep scares cartoony and allow anyone to pause the game without explanation.
- Let the birthday child choose a hero first. Give the remaining heroes equal chances to solve problems and make decisions.

Three-hour run of show

Time	Scene	What matters
0:00	Welcome and hero choice	Introduce characters, explain the d20, and hand out Make-a-Wish tokens.
0:15	Act 1: Bellweather Festival	Spotlight questions, the candle theft, and the runaway cake-cart challenge.
0:45	Act 2: Candywood	Frosting Gremlins and the Rainbow Gate puzzle.
1:25	Break	Snacks, bathroom, and a quick recap.
1:35	Act 3: Mooncake Tower	Roleplay trials, learn Pip's true wish, and meet Smudge.
2:10	Finale	Heart checks, boss encounter, and the candle countdown.
2:50	Epilogue	The shared wish, certificates, and favorite-moment recap.

The three golden rules

1. Say yes to good ideas. If an action is plausible and fun, let it work or call for a DC 10-13 check.

2. Failure changes the situation; it never stops the adventure. Reveal the clue, but add a cost, complication, or funny consequence.
3. End fights early when the outcome is clear. Enemies surrender, flee, or pop into harmless confetti at 0 hit points.

MAKE-A-WISH TOKEN

Each player starts with one. After any d20 roll, the player may spend it to reroll and keep either result. A token may also be given to another player. This is the packet's simple version of Inspiration.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Cast, Secrets, and Adventure Logic

What really happened

Pip Crumbleclaw, a young moon dragon, has watched Bellweather's parties from afar. Smudge the Gloom Moth whispered that the Starlight Candle could force everyone to become Pip's friends. Pip stole it, but does not want anyone hurt. Smudge intends to snuff the candle at moonrise, feeding on the whole town's disappointment.

THE EMOTIONAL CENTER

Pip does not need to be defeated. Pip needs to be invited. Smudge becomes much weaker when the heroes show that friendship cannot be stolen or wished into existence.

People and creatures

Name	First impression	What they want / know
Mayor Mallow	Flustered, kind, wearing a cake-shaped hat	Wants everyone safe. Saw silver sparkles trail toward Candywood.
Pip Crumbleclaw	Small blue-green dragon with icing on one horn	Wants friends and a party. Believes the candle is the only way.
Smudge	A velvet-black moth the size of a house cat	Feeds on hurt feelings. Fears honest invitations and bright laughter.
Frosting Gremlins	Tiny goblin-like bakers with spoon helmets	Want snacks, party hats, and a story worth repeating.
Sprig	A brave lantern sprite	Optional helper for two heroes or a struggling party.

Clues the heroes cannot miss

- A silver-blue scale dusted with icing identifies a young dragon, not a huge monster.

- Gremlins heard Smudge promise Pip, 'When the last flame goes dark, everyone will finally feel as lonely as you.'
- The tower walls show old paintings of Pip watching parties from outside the window.
- Pip's hoard is not gold. It is discarded invitations, ribbons, and carefully saved party hats.

Useful difficulty numbers

DC	Use it when...	Examples
10	The idea is sensible or the players are younger	Spot an obvious trail, calm a silly creature, leap a short gap.
12	Default challenge	Catch the cart, decode a clue, resist Smudge's doubt dust.
13	The attempt is risky, dramatic, or under time pressure	Swing from a banner, trick several enemies at once.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Act 1: The Festival and the Stolen Wish

Goal: introduce the heroes, give each player one early success, and point the party toward Candywood.

Target time: 25-30 minutes.

READ ALOUD

Bells ring over Bellweather Square as ribbons dance between the rooftops. At the center of the festival stands a cake taller than a wagon, topped by one silver candle whose flame looks exactly like a tiny star. Mayor Mallow lifts a cake-shaped hat and calls, 'Heroes, guests, and birthday celebrants - welcome to the Festival of First Stars!'

Give everyone a spotlight question

- What ridiculous present did your hero bring?
- What party food can your hero never resist?
- How does everyone in Bellweather already know your hero?

Reward a confident or funny answer with a cheer, not an extra mechanical bonus. Every hero already has one Make-a-Wish token.

The theft

READ ALOUD

A cold gust snaps the ribbons. Something blue-green swoops over the cake. WHOOSH! The silver candle vanishes between two little dragon claws, and a velvet-black moth flutters after it. 'Sorry!' the dragon yelps. 'I need the wish more!' At that exact moment, a cake cart rolls downhill toward a fountain full of ducklings.

Challenge: Stop the runaway cake cart

Ask each player what their hero does. The group needs 4 successes before 2 setbacks; default DC 13. No hero may make the same kind of attempt twice.

- Athletics: grab the handle, brace a wheel, or push a market stall aside.
- Acrobatics: leap onto the cart, swing from a ribbon, or steer through the crowd.
- Animal Handling: convince the parade goats to block the lane.
- Investigation or Perception: spot the brake lever or a safer route.
- Magic, Performance, or another clever plan: judge by the idea, usually DC 10-12.

FAIL FORWARD

On success, the cart stops inches from the ducklings and Mayor Mallow gives each hero a Frosting Favor. On a mixed result, it lands softly in a hay cart; give the group one shared Favor. Either way, icing on the wheel reveals a silver-blue scale and a sparkling trail toward Candywood.

Frosting Favor

A hero can eat this as a bonus action to regain 1d4 + 1 hit points. It smells like the hero's favorite dessert. One use.

Transition

Mayor Mallow asks the heroes to recover the candle before moonrise, but adds: 'Bring the little thief back safely if you can. Anyone who says sorry while escaping probably has more story to tell.'

GM-ONLY SECTION

Act 2: Candywood

Goal: deliver one social-or-combat encounter, reveal Smudge's plan, and give the heroes a simple shared puzzle. Target time: 35-45 minutes.

READ ALOUD

The trail enters Candywood, where peppermint reeds sway beside a stream of fizzy water. Ahead, a bridge is blocked by four tiny figures in frosting-smeared aprons. Their spoon helmets glitter. The tallest points a whisk and squeaks, 'Toll! One excellent snack, one excellent joke, or one excellent battle!'

Scene A: The Sprinkle Bridge

The four Frosting Gremlins are not loyal to Smudge. They want entertainment and can be passed in any of these ways:

- Share one Frosting Favor or another snack. The gremlins also return a crumpled clue note.
- Tell a joke, perform, or invent a party game. One good idea succeeds; otherwise use DC 13 Performance.
- Win a quick contest: best hat, loudest dragon noise, or three opposed d20 rolls with any fitting skill.
- Fight. When two gremlins fall, the others surrender and explain what they overheard.

Frosting Gremlin - quick combat

AC 12; HP 7 each; Speed 30 ft.; Initiative +2. Spoon Smack: +4 to hit, 1d4 + 2 bludgeoning. Frosting Glob: ranged +4, 20/60 ft., 1d4 + 2 cold; target's speed is reduced by 10 ft. until the start of the gremlin's next turn. Sugar Rush: once per fight, move 15 ft. without provoking opportunity attacks.

WHAT THEY OVERHEARD

The moth told Pip, 'At moonrise, snuff the four little flames around the candle. When the last one goes dark, everyone will understand how lonely you are.' The gremlins thought that sounded 'extremely un-party-like.'

Scene B: The Rainbow Gate

A candy-stone arch blocks the tower path. Four flavor buttons - Cocoa, Berry, Lemon, and Mint - must be pressed in order. Read the three carved clues:

PUZZLE CLUES

Berry appears before Mint. Lemon stands immediately before Mint. Cocoa is neither first nor last.

Answer: Berry, Cocoa, Lemon, Mint. Let the group solve it aloud. On a wrong press, a harmless confetti burst gives that hero disadvantage on their next Stealth check and advantage on their next Performance check. After two wrong tries, a peppermint bird chirps the next correct flavor.

Optional discovery

A DC 10 Investigation check finds Pip's hoard tucked behind the gate: worn ribbons, old invitations, and a tiny card that reads, 'Maybe next year someone will remember me.' Award a Make-a-Wish token to any hero who suggests inviting Pip before the finale.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Act 3: Mooncake Tower

Goal: turn the chase into a choice. The heroes learn what Pip wants, weaken Smudge through empathy, and enter the finale. Target time before combat: 30-35 minutes.

READ ALOUD

Mooncake Tower rises above the trees like a stack of silver pancakes. Inside, moonlight glows along a spiral stair. Three bells hang over the first landing, engraved COURAGE, CLEVERNESS, and KINDNESS. Beyond them, a small dragon voice says, 'Do you think they'll come when I make the wish?' A softer voice answers, 'Oh, everyone will come...eventually.'

Trial 1: The Three Bells

The door opens after all three bells ring. Ask each player to choose one bell and describe a moment when their hero showed that quality. No roll is needed. If someone is stuck, another player may describe what they admire about that hero.

Trial 2: The Hall of Echoed Wishes

In the next room, painted stars whisper, 'A wish only for yourself is too small to open the sky.' Ask each player for a harmless wish. The next door opens when at least one hero wishes something kind for someone else. If needed, a painting of Pip watching a party provides the hint.

The rooftop

READ ALOUD

On the moonlit roof, Pip curls around the Starlight Candle. Four tiny flames circle its silver wick. Beside the dragon, Smudge spreads wings that swallow the light. 'They came to take it,' the moth purrs. Pip's claws tighten, but tears sparkle at the corners of those enormous eyes. 'I only wanted one party where someone saved me a seat.'

Heart checks before initiative

The group needs 3 successes before 2 setbacks, default DC 13. Every player must contribute before anyone repeats a skill. Good gifts or honest invitations may succeed without a roll.

- Insight: name what Pip is really afraid of.
- Persuasion: promise a place at the party without promising that everyone will always agree.
- Performance: begin a silly birthday song or dragon dance.
- History or Investigation: point to the saved invitations and explain that wanting connection is not wrong.
- Any creative action: offering a hat, sharing a wish, or asking Pip to help save the candle.

RESULT

On 3 successes, Pip joins the heroes: Smudge starts with 10 fewer hit points and cannot use Dust of Doubt in round 1. On 2 setbacks first, Smudge attacks at full strength - but Pip can still be reached during the fight.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Finale: Smudge and the Four Flames

The goal is not simply to reduce hit points. Keep the candle's four flames lit, protect Pip, and drive Smudge away. Put four coins beside the candle to track the countdown.

Finale rules

- At the end of each round, Smudge snuffs one flame unless a hero spent an action that round guarding or relighting the candle.
- A hero adjacent to Pip may use an action for a DC 13 Persuasion, Performance, or another heartfelt check. At 2 total successes, Pip uses Star Breath immediately.
- Star Breath: Smudge takes 2d8 radiant damage, every hero ends the frightened condition, and one extinguished flame relights.
- If all four flames go dark, the wish is not lost. Each hero immediately spends their Make-a-Wish token if they still have it; the shared magic relights one flame and Smudge takes 1d8 damage per token. If no tokens remain, Pip relights one flame by making a wish for the heroes instead of for himself.
- Smudge flees at 0 HP, after three successful heartfelt actions, or whenever the ending feels earned. It collapses into a palm-sized gray moth and escapes into the night.

Smudge, Gloom Moth

Medium fey; AC 14; HP 50 (40 if the heart checks succeeded); Speed 10 ft., fly 40 ft.; Initiative +3. Saves: Dex +5, Wis +3. Resistant to necrotic damage. Smudge cannot be frightened.

Wing Swipe. Melee attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft.; 1d8 + 3 necrotic damage.

Dust of Doubt (Recharge 5-6). Creatures in a 15-ft. cone make a DC 13 Wisdom save. On a failure, take 2d6 psychic damage and become frightened until the end of the creature's next turn. On a success, take half damage and are not frightened.

Not Invited! (Reaction, once per round). After being hit, Smudge flies up to 10 ft. without provoking opportunity attacks.

Tactics. Smudge targets a confident hero with Dust of Doubt, then circles the candle. Smudge boasts, bargains, and complains; it never attacks an unconscious hero.

Gloomlings (3)

Tiny shadow fey; AC 12; HP 5 each; Speed 25 ft., fly 25 ft.; Initiative +2. Sulky Scratch: +4 to hit, 1d4 + 2 psychic damage. Pop! At 0 HP, a gloomling bursts into harmless black confetti. A hero beside it may catch a silver spark and regain 1d4 HP.

KEEP IT MOVING

If the heroes are winning easily, add one gloomling at the start of round 3. If they are struggling, Pip uses Star Breath after the first hero speaks kindly, with no roll. Never make children grind through the last few hit points.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Epilogue, Rewards, and Easy Adjustments

The shared wish

READ ALOUD

The four flames leap together and become one bright star. Pip closes both eyes. 'I wish,' the dragon says slowly, 'that everyone who wants a friend finds the courage to ask.' The star rises over Bellweather - and then bursts into a thousand warm lights, each one shaped like a tiny birthday candle.

Ask each player to narrate one detail of the restored party: a food, a decoration, a game, or an unexpected guest. Pip receives a real invitation. Mayor Mallow gives each hero a Starwish Pin and declares them Heroes of Bellweather.

Starwish Pin

Once in a future adventure, the wearer can turn a failed check into a success by explaining whom the success will help. Afterward, the pin becomes an ordinary silver star.

Difficulty and age dial

Group	Checks	Final encounter
New players	Use DC 12; offer a hint after one failed attempt.	Smudge HP 42; two gloomlings; Pip helps after one kind action.
Age 13 / default	Use DC 13 and the printed challenges.	Smudge HP 50; three gloomlings; standard four-flame countdown.
Experienced players	Use DC 14; add costs on mixed results.	Smudge HP 58; four gloomlings; first snuff happens immediately.

If the table has only two players plus a GM

Each player chooses a hero and starts with two Make-a-Wish tokens. Use Smudge at 32 HP with one gloomling. Sprig the lantern sprite follows them: AC 13, HP 15; Star Bolt +4 to hit, 1d6 + 2 radiant; once per round Sprig can use Help as a bonus action. Let the players decide Sprig's target.

Time trims

- For a two-hour game, make the cake-cart challenge 3 successes before 2 setbacks, and let the Rainbow Gate open after one clue is solved.
- For a ninety-minute game, narrate the Candywood crossing and run only the tower plus finale.
- If the bridge combat runs long, the remaining gremlins surrender as soon as one is defeated and any hero offers terms.

Closing the session

Give each player a certificate, then ask: 'What was your hero's bravest, cleverest, or kindest moment?' Finish with applause for all three heroes and one final birthday cheer.

PLAYER HANDOUT

Your Invitation to Bellweather

Bring a brave heart, a clever plan, and room for cake.

INVITATION

Birthday Hero: _____

Mayor Mallow requests the honor of your heroic company at the Festival of First Stars in Bellweather Square. Festive clothes, unusual gifts, and heroic appetites are encouraged. Dragon-sized seating will be arranged if necessary.

Your mission

A magical candle has been stolen. Follow the sparkling trail, keep the wish safe, and remember: the creature in your way may need help as much as the people behind you.

Clue card: The Rainbow Gate**CUT OUT OR READ ALOUD**

BERRY appears before MINT.

LEMON stands immediately before MINT.

COCOA is neither first nor last.

Press: 1) _____ 2) _____ 3) _____ 4) _____

Clue note from the bridge**CUT OUT AFTER THE GREMLINS**

The moth told Pip: 'At moonrise, snuff the four little flames. When the last one goes dark, everyone will understand how lonely you are.'

Make-a-Wish token

Circle this star when used: ☆ After any d20 roll, reroll and keep either result. You may give this token to another hero.

PROTECTOR - DWARF FIGHTER**Bramble Stoneheart**

You are steady as a castle wall, warm as a bakery oven, and secretly delighted by ridiculous hats. Your goal: make sure nobody gets left behind. Catchphrase: 'No one gets left off the guest list.'

AC	HP	Speed	Initiative	Proficiency
18	31	25 ft.	+1	+2

Current HP: _____ / 31 Make-a-Wish: ☆ Frosting Favor: □

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	13 (+1)	8 (-1)

Best skills

Athletics +5; Perception +3; Insight +3; Survival +3. Strength save +5; Constitution save +4.

Attacks

Attack	Roll	On a hit
Longsword	d20 + 5	1d8 + 3 slashing
Javelin (30/120 ft.)	d20 + 5	1d6 + 3 piercing
Shield Bash	d20 + 5	1d4 + 3; push 5 ft. if target is your size or smaller

Special abilities

- Second Wind (bonus action, once per short rest): regain 1d10 + 3 HP.
- Action Surge (once per short rest): take one extra action on your turn.
- Protective Intercept (reaction, twice per adventure): when an ally within 5 ft. takes damage, reduce it by 1d6 + 2.
- Dwarven Grit: advantage on saves against poison; darkvision 60 ft.

SNEAK - HALFLING ROGUE**Nyx Underbough**

You can open any lock except the cookie tin at home. You notice what others miss and make bravery look like a prank. Your goal: solve the mystery first. Catchphrase: 'I meant to do that quietly.'

AC	HP	Speed	Initiative	Proficiency
15	24	25 ft.	+3	+2

Current HP: _____ / 24 Make-a-Wish: ☆ Frosting Favor: □

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)

Best skills

Stealth +7; Acrobatics +5; Investigation +3; Perception +3; Persuasion +4. Dexterity save +5; Intelligence save +3.

Attacks

Attack	Roll	On a hit
Shortbow (80/320 ft.)	d20 + 5	1d6 + 3 piercing
Shortsword	d20 + 5	1d6 + 3 piercing
Dagger (20/60 ft.)	d20 + 5	1d4 + 3 piercing

Special abilities

- Sneak Attack (once per turn): add 2d6 damage when you have advantage, or when an ally is beside the target and you do not have disadvantage.
- Cunning Action (bonus action): Dash, Disengage, or Hide.
- Halfling Luck: when you roll a natural 1 on a d20, reroll it.
- Quick Fingers: thieves' tools +5; you may use a bonus action for a simple lock, lever, pocket, or trap interaction.

MAGIC AND SUPPORT - HALF-ELF BARD**Elio Starstring**

You collect songs, strange friends, and dramatic entrances. Your magic can heal a bruise or turn a whisper into thunder. Your goal: make this adventure a story worth singing.

AC	HP	Speed	Initiative	Spell DC
14	24	30 ft.	+2	13

Current HP: _____ / 24 Make-a-Wish: ☆ Inspiration dice: ☐ ☐ ☐

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)

Best skills and attacks

Performance +5; Persuasion +5; Arcana +3; Insight +2. Rapier: d20 + 4, 1d8 + 2 piercing. Light crossbow (80/320 ft.): d20 + 4, 1d8 + 2 piercing. Spell attack +5; spell save DC 13.

Bardic Inspiration

Bonus action, 3 times per long rest: give a hero within 60 ft. a d6. Within 10 minutes, that hero can add it to one ability check, attack roll, or saving throw after rolling but before the result is known.

Spells

Cantrips: Sparkle Taunt and Mage Hand. Spell slots: 1st level ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ 2nd level ☐ ☐

Spell	Use	Short effect
Sparkle Taunt	Cantrip	Target within 60 ft. makes Wis save; 1d4 psychic and disadvantage on its next attack.
Healing Word	Bonus, 1st	Hero within 60 ft. regains 1d4 + 3 HP.
Dissonant Whispers	Action, 1st	Wis save; 3d6 psychic and target uses reaction to move away; half damage on save.
Faerie Fire	Action, 1st	Creatures in a 20-ft. cube make Dex save; failed targets glow and attacks against them have advantage.
Thunderwave	Action, 1st	15-ft. cube; Con save; 2d8 thunder and push 10 ft.; half/no push on save.
Shatter	Action, 2nd	10-ft. radius within 60 ft.; Con save; 3d8 thunder, half on save.

How to Play in Five Minutes

THE BASIC RULE

Say what your hero tries. If success is uncertain, roll a d20 and add the matching bonus. If the total meets or beats the Game Master's difficulty (usually 12-13) or an enemy's Armor Class, you succeed.

On your turn

4. Move up to your speed. You may move before and after your action.
5. Take one action: attack, cast a spell, Dash, Disengage, Dodge, Help, Hide, guard the candle, or try something creative.
6. Use one bonus action if an ability says it is a bonus action.
7. Use one reaction between your turns if a feature or opportunity attack allows it.

Helpful rules

- Advantage: roll two d20s and use the higher. Disadvantage: use the lower. They do not stack.
- Critical hit: a natural 20 on an attack hits and rolls the attack's damage dice twice, then adds the bonus once.
- Opportunity attack: when a nearby enemy leaves your reach without Disengaging, you may use your reaction for one melee attack.
- Help: give an ally advantage on one relevant check, or on an attack against a creature within 5 ft. of you.
- At 0 HP: you fall unconscious and begin death saves on your turns. Roll d20: 10+ is a success, 9 or less a failure. Three successes stabilize; three failures mean the hero needs urgent magic. Healing wakes you immediately.
- Creative play: describe the goal, the method, and what makes it possible. The Game Master decides whether it works automatically or needs a roll.

Team reminders

Bramble	Nyx	Elio
Protect nearby allies.	Fight beside an ally for Sneak Attack.	Inspire early; heal fallen allies.
Action Surge: guard + attack.	Cunning Action reaches the candle.	Faerie Fire helps everyone hit.

PRINT ONE COPY FOR EACH PLAYER

BY DECREE OF MAYOR MALLOW AND THE PEOPLE OF BELLWEATHER

Certificate of Starry Heroism

This certificate is proudly awarded to

for courage, cleverness, kindness, and excellent service in the recovery of the Starlight Candle.

OFFICIAL COMMENDATION

This hero faced runaway cake, crossed the Candywood, climbed Mooncake Tower, protected a magical wish, and proved that the finest adventures save room for one more friend.

Awarded on _____ Game Master _____

★ HERO OF BELLWEATHER ★

May your next wish be brave, generous, and just a little bit ridiculous.